

Title

Factors influencing parental engagement in child oral health and quality-of-life outcomes

Abstract

Secondary analysis examined parental factors and child quality-of-life outcomes from the baseline cross-sectional assessment. Parental self-reported confidence in ability to promote good oral habits (self-efficacy) was the strongest independent predictor of better child oral health-related quality of life (beta=-0.16, 95% CI -0.24 to -0.09, $p<0.001$), indicating children of higher-efficacy parents reported fewer oral-health-related functional limitations and discomfort. Parental knowledge about cavity prevention mechanisms and fluoride benefits showed weaker associations. Household income significantly predicted both parental self-efficacy and child caries outcomes; low-income families showed lower self-efficacy and higher caries rates. Maternal education level correlated positively with parental self-efficacy ($r=0.28$, $p<0.001$). Among children with caries, quality-of-life impairment included self-consciousness about appearance (32%), eating difficulties (18%), and school absenteeism (8%). Parental self-efficacy mediated the relationship between household socioeconomic factors and child caries risk. These findings highlight that increasing parental confidence in preventive capacity, rather than knowledge alone, may address disparities in childhood oral health outcomes.